



DRAWING A NEW WORLD: Artist Anil Kumar at Gallery OED

ART MARKETS

Kochi | KERALA



Beyond the bazaar

An exhibition space that builds a relationship, a gallery that nurtures talent. It's here in seeming somnolence.

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

When their paintings, exhibited at the Kashi Art Gallery in 2005, fetched a few lakhs each, 27-year-old T. Ratheesh, 34-year-old George Martin and 28-year-old Prajakt Palav, couldn't believe their luck. Now they are all established names in the art world, almost inured to

the rising art prices. "Discover New Talent" was the motto for Anup Skaria, 47, an artist from Kochi and 46-year-old Dorrie Younger, his American art critic wife, when they set up the 1,000-sq-foot Kashi Art Café—Kerala's first art café—in 1997, in a two century-old Dutch building in the historic Fort Kochi. And they couldn't be hap-

pier. "Kerala's young artists had to go and work in Mumbai or Delhi to earn recognition and money. There were neither many galleries in the state nor a market for paintings. We started the art café where artists could display their work and hang around," says Skaria, a short story writer and art enthusiast who got the idea when he was on a visit to Vienna in Austria. Soon Kashi Art Café became a huge hit among artists and tourists (not the least because of its coffee from hand-ground beans and lemon cheese cake). Kashi began offering residencies for young talents with a scholarship of Rs 5,000 a month. "We don't force any conditions on the artists. Anyone can apply for a residency scholarship and those selected can stay, paint, sculpt or do

nothing at all. They don't have to give or sell their work to us," says Younger.

Kashi has also instituted the Kashi Award for Visual Art for young artists. "Young artists of the state no longer have to flee Kerala to be recognised. Kashi's contribution in this change is pioneering," says Rajan M. Krishnan, 40, an artist. Skaria has also set up an art retreat on the picturesque Kakkathuruth island off the famed Vembanad backwaters near Kochi, intended for young artists.

Kashi's success appears to be catching on. Gallery OED, a new gallery intended for young artists was opened in Kochi recently. "Until recently only tourists used to buy paintings in Kerala. Not any more thanks to galleries like Kashi and OED," says Anil Kumar, a young artist.